

The Falcon, By Wolf Devoured

Does Mere, the Goddess of Messengers, know anything of joy?

Mere
 Once 

Stormwatch Keep sat atop a cliff overlooking the Bay of Goletha. It was named for its express purpose, in rather blunt Qastran fashion. To protect the interior from the worst of the storms, the sea-facing wall was helmed by a sloped roof that deflected the brunt of the winds. But that roof, and despite it, left the keep's interior dark, close, and irretrievably damp.

The Falcon God of Messengers stepped into a weak glow of torchlight that had stretched itself from a handful of torches on every far end of the Keep's south tower, which housed a small but functional Marshall's Gate. Directly across from her was the only exit to the room, even more abandoned by the torchlight than the Gate's exit. In the shadow of that doorway she saw a pair of Legionaires, given away by the glint of their polished armor.

One of those shadowed soldiers spoke up, "Who comes hence unbidden? What host do you herald?"

"I herald none but myself," Mere answered, measuring her tone. "I am the Falcon of Naris, and I carry with me messages for the posts of the keep and the manor town below." She patted the satchel slung across her body. It wasn't *brimming* with letters, but had been enough to warrant coming through by gate.

Muttered discussion reached her ears as a low hum along the stones. A different voice responded, "My watch partner is newly sworn, lady Falcon. He has not yet learned to recognize your signs. I hope that the Gods of Naris are not offended."

"Not in the slightest," she said. "I applaud your caution and acknowledge your deference. May I see myself to your postmaster?"

Mere delivers a formal letter declining an offer of courtship to a young officer in Qastra (where are they? how does that inform the introduction?). The lad, not much younger than Mere, is relieved to have confirmation of his suspicion and also immediately enamored with a mysterious woman carrying messages while hiding her face behind the visage of a falcon. He immediately attempts to win her attention and even her affections.

Mere, having never received such attention, reacts with a mix of shock and intrigue. She permits herself to remain and allow the young man to ask her about herself.

From this conversation, she is made keenly aware how little, still, of her life has been of her choosing. Sensing her shift in mood, and general grave demeanor, he asks her "does the Goddess of Messengers know anything of joy?"

In answer, she brings him to a field of flowers kept cultivated near to the Marshall's Gate outside the city. The young man clearly seeks intimacy. He wants to see the face she will not show to others.

She is hesitant, but eventually agrees. He kisses her, she reciprocates, and they have a tryst in the field of flowers.

After, he talks about the oaths he will need to take to finish becoming an officer of the Legion, and that he hesitated to be pressed to that degree of service. He does not want to be bound to something bigger than himself. He wants small life, small love, and maybe to see the world.

Mere offers to show him something more than their world. She takes him through the Gate to the Bridge, showing him the many doors the Realm presents to them, which ones lead back to Veneth and which go Elsewhere.

He asks if she has ever been to Another Place, just to visit. She reflects that her mentor forbade it, citing how different and dangerous another world can be. But he tells her that she is not wearing the mask now, that they both can return to their duty later, and what harm is there in paying a simple visit?

They select a door that is a passage between two trees, and from which the scent of honey wafts. It is a door to Harrows, and they pass through it.

At first their visit is pleasant. There is honey and fruit and warmth and beauty. But the world also seems to shift around them. Time slips away from them. The young man is claimed first, seized with a need to remain, and he convinces her to stay as well. She crafts a set of rings for them out of grass. She slowly begins to forget Veneth, and her concerns over the Wilds and Thrast.

And one day, the young man is gone. Does he become a wolf? Is he literally eaten by Harrows? By whatever means, it becomes clear that the place Mere has come to is a predator, and it does not mean to let her leave.

With great effort and striving, she uses her lingering Associations as the Falcon to carve her exit from Harrows, but that is not enough. She has to bind the place away from the Bridge and from Veneth (because it means to follow its prey beyond the bounds of its own existence). It is Harrows that turns her grass ring to Iron. It is the Falcon who swears an oath.

This ring's purpose was stolen. It cannot be returned, because it was a promise and it was broken. So long as I still wear this broken promise, this Iron Ring, the thief of that purpose is barred the passage of any door and cannot seek shelter without being driven off.

But the promise, broken, lingers. And this place, harrowed and harried by her curse, harrowing for those who touch it, lingers in Mere's mind. She cannot eject it without releasing her curse, because it was already within her, and leaving her would be passage through a door.

That kind of bond, but without the rage and judgment and compromise to something terrible, is the inspiration of the nature of the Circle's bond (which is why this is the Edification flashback for Mere).